

NT40 Enrichment

†1. **Introduction and Timeline for Philippians and Colossians:** “Philippians and Colossians were probably both written while Paul was under arrest in Rome, but remarkably it was during this difficult time that Paul wrote of “the peace of God, which passeth all understanding” (Philippians 4:7). These two epistles are consistently positive and optimistic, and they contain some of Paul’s clearest and most earnest teachings about Jesus Christ. Paul taught that if we live in faith and gratitude, the Lord can further the gospel cause through us—no matter what circumstances we might be in—and that by building upon the foundation of Jesus Christ we can avoid being led astray by worldly philosophies and traditions. (*New Testament Student Manual: Religion 211-212*, [Chapter 45: Philippians and Colossians](#))

New Testament Student Manual: Religion 211-212, [Chapter 45: Philippians and Colossians](#): Search for **Philippians 2:1-7**. “Esteem Other Better Than Themselves”

†2. **H. Burke Peterson:** “To paraphrase a statement made by **Wendell Phillips**, it may be accurately said, “How prudently most men sink into nameless graves, while now and then a few *forget themselves* into immortality.” (as quoted by William Jennings Bryan, *The Prince of Peace*, Independence: Zion’s Printing and Publishing Co., 1925.)

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“A selfless person is one who is more concerned about the happiness and well-being of another than about his or her own convenience or comfort, one who is willing to serve another when it is neither sought for nor appreciated, or one who is willing to serve even those whom he or she dislikes. A selfless person displays a willingness to sacrifice, a willingness to purge from his or her mind and heart personal wants, and needs, and feelings. Instead of reaching for and requiring praise and recognition for himself, or gratification of his or her own wants, the selfless person will meet these very human needs for others. Remember the words of the Savior as he taught his disciples on an occasion when personal recognition was being sought: “But Jesus called them to him, and saith unto them, ... whosoever will be great among you, shall be your minister: And whosoever of you will be the chiefest, shall be servant of all. For even the son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give his life a ransom for many.” (Mark 10:42–45.) (“[Selflessness: a Pattern for Happiness](#),” *Ensign*, May 1985)

†3. **Elder Tad R. Callister:** “God the Son traded his heavenly home with all its celestial adornments for a mortal abode with all its primitive trappings. He, ‘the King of heaven’ (Alma 5:50), ‘the Lord Omnipotent who reigneth’ (Mosiah 5:3), left a throne to inherit a manger.

He exchanged the dominion of a god for the dependence of a babe. He gave up wealth, power, dominion, and the fullness of his glory—for what?—for taunting, mocking, humiliation, and subjection. It was a trade of unparalleled dimension, a condescension of incredible proportions, a descent of incalculable depth” (*The Infinite Atonement* [2000], 64).

†4. **Elder Dallin H. Oaks:** “Man unquestionably has impressive powers and can bring to pass great things by tireless efforts and indomitable will. But after all our obedience and good works, we cannot be saved from the effect of our sins without the grace extended by the atonement of Jesus Christ” (“[What Think Ye of Christ?](#)” *Ensign*, Nov. 1988, 66–67).

†5. **Elder Bruce R. McConkie:** “When the saints suffer persecution for righteousness/ sake, they stand in the place and stead of Christ and are receiving what the ungodly would heap upon the Son of God were he personally present.” (*Doctrinal New Testament Commentary*, 2:530)

†6. **Joseph Smith:** “Those who cannot endure persecution, and stand in the day of affliction, cannot stand in the day when the Son of God shall burst the veil, and appear in all the glory of His Father, with all the holy angels.” (*Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, p. 42)

†7. **Elder Boyd K. Packer:** “As the years passed I found that, while not easy, I could control my thoughts if I made a place for them to go. You can replace thoughts of temptation, anger, disappointment, or fear with better thoughts—with music.”

“Thoughts are talks we hold with ourselves. Do you see why the scriptures tell us to ‘let virtue garnish [thy] thoughts unceasingly’ and promise us that if we do, our ‘confidence [shall] wax strong in the presence of God; and the doctrine of the priesthood shall distil upon [our] soul[s] as the dew from heaven’ and then ‘the Holy Ghost shall be [our] constant companion’.” (Conference Report, Oct. 1999)

†8. **Lloyd D. Newell:** “When we approach the ‘rough’ in life with a positive attitude and a humble dependence upon God, it is amazing how the rocky road we were once traveling can become so much more smooth. The nature of ‘the road’ really does not change, but our capacity to walk it increases when we turn to God for support. We, like Paul, will then say to ourselves: ‘I can do all things through Christ which strengtheneth me.’” (*The Divine Connection*, p. 06)

†9. **President Ezra Taft Benson:** “God help us to be grateful for our blessings, never to be guilty of the sin of ingratitude, and to instill this same gratitude into the lives of our children. Someone has said that an ungrateful man is like a hog under a tree eating apples and never looking up to see where they come from. And the Lord has said, ‘And he who receiveth all things with thankfulness shall be made glorious; and the things of this earth shall be added unto him, even an hundred fold, yea, more’ (D&C 78:19). This great principle of gratitude, made a daily part of our lives and our prayers, can lift and bless us as individuals, as members of the Church, and as parents and families.” (*Teachings of Ezra Taft Benson*, p. 264)

†10. **Ted L. Gibbons:** “Philemon lived in Colosse. He was, in the pattern of the day, a slave owner. In fact the Roman Empire at this time included about 10,000,000 slaves. One of the slaves, Onesimus, had apparently stolen something from him (see v. 18) and then had run away to Rome where he met Paul and was converted. Under Roman law, actions were punishable by death, but Paul wrote to ask Philemon to forgive whatever debt Onesimus owed, and to accept him as a brother in Christ. In fact, Paul offered himself as a surety for the loss suffered by Philemon: ‘If he hath wronged thee, or oweth thee ought, put that on mine account.’ (Philemon 1:18)

“You can identify with this dilemma. Suppose a non-Mormon friend or neighbor has stolen your new Lexus and fled to Salt Lake City where, by great good fortune, he encounters one of the Twelve. While you are stewing and fuming at your loss, a letter comes from the Church Administration Building, from the office of a prophet, seer, and revelator. The letter tells you how a church leader met your corrupt neighbor, and of his conversion to the Gospel.

“I know what he has done to you,” he writes. “If the debt must be paid, send the bill to me. I’ll take care of it. But receive this man not as a thief, and not even as a neighbor, but as ‘a brother beloved, specially to me, but how much more unto thee, both in the flesh and in the Lord’ (Philemon 1:15).

“How would you react to such a letter? What bill would you send? What grudge would you nourish?

“Someone once suggested to me that I read Philemon as though it were a letter from the Savior to me, asking me to forgive someone. You might consider reading it in that way, all the while asking yourself these questions: ‘Whom do I need to forgive?’ and ‘How can I let the Lord know that I have done so?’” ([New Testament Sunday School Lesson 40: “I Can Do All Things Through Christ”](#), at LDSLiving, Sep. 20, 2015.)

†11. **Nancy Jensen:** “These three epistles emphasize the importance of the Atonement in our lives, that without Christ we cannot succeed, but as we follow him, we cannot only be saved in the next life, but we can achieve

peace and joy in this life, regardless of circumstances. Several key elements of happiness are found in these three small epistles. We’ll work our way backwards from the smallest to the largest. If you are struggling with finding joy in life right now, pay close attention to see if you can find a key that you can implement in your life that may restore your happiness.

†12. **Lenet Hadley Read:**

“III. Another way to find Oneness is, as Paul wrote the Colossians, ‘... above all these things, put on charity, which is the bond of perfectness’ (Col 3:14).

“A. How is charity a bond of perfectness?

“B. A major way for a group to grow in perfectness together is not by telling each other their faults, but to not seek for faults. It is rather to cover others weaknesses unless serious and necessary to expose them.

“C. Joseph Smith explained this marvelous truth in our day:

“1. ‘If you do not accuse each other, God will not accuse you. If you have no accuser you will enter heaven ... If you will throw a cloak of charity over my sins, I will over yours—for charity covereth a multitude of sins (HC 4:445).

“D. Under these guidelines, Paul later asks charity from Philemon—to forgive his slave, Onesimus, who robbed him and then ran away, and even to accept him now as an equal—a brother in Christ, since he had repented and found the Savior (Philemon 1:9-21).” (New Testament 40 “I Can Do All Things through Christ” (Philippians; Colossians; Philemon)

†13. **Lenet Hadley Read:**

“V...

“D. And he gives a timely warning to all: ‘Beware lest any man spoil you through philosophy and vain deceit, after the tradition of men, after the rudiments of the world’ (Colossians 2:8).

“1. This warning applies to our day as well. It is tragic that as the time comes closer and closer for the coming of Christ with all its terrifying judgments, when all in our day should be hearkening more closely to the words of the Lord through His appointed servants, that more and more are being spoiled through philosophy and vain deceit and the traditions of the world.

“2. Thus they are pulling away from the very sources of strength they need for the most challenging of all times.” (New Testament 40 “I Can Do All Things through Christ” (Philippians; Colossians; Philemon)

†14. **Lenet Hadley Read:** “VI. A personal Account of overcoming hard things through Christ.”

[Note: Lenet tells a powerful story about accomplishing a very difficult pageant and of a miraculous conversion that came from it.] (New Testament 40 “I Can Do All Things through Christ” (Philippians; Colossians; Philemon)

Recommended Conference Talks:

Dallin H. Oaks, “[Teachings of Jesus](#),” *Ensign*, November 2011.

Quentin L. Cook, “[The Songs They Could Not Sing](#),” *Ensign*, November 2011.

Russell M. Nelson, “[Face the Future with Faith](#),” *Ensign*, May 2011.

Walter F. González, “[Followers of Christ](#),” *Ensign*, May 2011.

Robert D. Hales, “[Waiting upon the Lord: Thy Will Be Done](#),” *Ensign*, November 2011.

Russell M. Nelson, “[Covenants](#),” *Ensign*, November 2011.

Recommended Reading:

1. Nancy Jensen, [New Testament Lesson #40 "I Can Do All Things Through Christ"](#), LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus, October 7, 2011.

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